Bootz Footwear: SWOT Analysis and Proposed E-Commerce Solutions

Submitted by: Bootbase



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Abstract

This report presents an overview of Bootz Footwear, a premier retailer of footwear and handbags based in Nugegoda, Sri Lanka. The project highlights the company's background, market position, and unique strengths such as its modern store layout, stylish product offerings, and strategic location. It also addresses the challenges the business faces in a competitive and economically volatile retail environment. The purpose of this study is to establish a foundation for e-commerce solutions that will expand Bootz's market reach, improve product visibility, and strengthen customer trust. By examining the company's context and initial challenges, this report sets the stage for exploring strategic digital initiatives to enhance long-term competitiveness in the fashion retail industry.

Acknowledgement

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Finally, we wish to acknowledge the inspiration provided by Bootz Footwear as a case study, which allowed me to explore practical solutions for modern retail challenges.

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Introduction

This project focuses on Bootz Footwear, a well-established footwear and handbag retailer strategically based in Nugegoda, Sri Lanka.

Over the years, Bootz has built a reputation for delivering premium-quality, stylish, and durable products that appeal to fashion-conscious consumers. The company is recognized as a premier retailer of both footwear and handbags, offering a curated range of stylish, high-quality designs that combine comfort with fashion. Its brand identity is built on trust and quality, ensuring that every product meets the expectations of modern shoppers. A key strength of the business is its store atmosphere: the outlet is designed with a modern and visually appealing layout that attracts trendy customers and provides them with an exceptional shopping experience. Strategically located at the busy Nugegoda junction, the store benefits from significant foot traffic, making it an accessible and attractive destination for regular and new customers alike. Bootz caters primarily to fashion-conscious individuals who value premium quality, stylish designs, and durability in their footwear and accessories.

By combining its prime location, strong product offerings, and modern store layout, the company has positioned itself as a trusted and desirable retail brand in Sri Lanka. However, with changing customer expectations, economic fluctuations, and rising competition, Bootz must continue to evolve. This project therefore aims to analyze the company's current context, highlight its strengths and challenges, and propose innovative e-commerce solutions that will expand its reach, improve visibility, and strengthen its competitive edge in the fashion retail market.

Vision and Mission

The vision and mission statements define the long-term direction and core purpose of Bootz Footwear. They guide the company's strategy and reflect its commitment to customers.

Vision

The vision of Bootz Footwear is to be Sri Lanka's most trusted footwear and accessories brand, combining style, quality, and technology to deliver an exceptional shopping experience.

Mission

The mission of Bootz Footwear is to provide stylish, high-quality footwear through both in-store and online platforms, ensuring availability, affordability, and personalized service that keeps every customer walking with confidence.





SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis helps Bootz Footwear understand its strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats. It highlights what the company does well, areas for improvement, potential growth opportunities, and external risks. This analysis guides us to take the right e-commerce solutions for Bootz Footwear.

Strengths

1.Stylish and high-quality footwear - Bootz offers footwear that are both fashionable and well-made. This style and quality appeal to customers who are looking for products that are trendy yet durable, giving Bootz an advantage over competitors.

2.Products are trusted for durability and design - Customers rely on Bootz products because they are built to last and have attractive designs. This trust in product quality strengthens the brand's reputation and encourages repeat purchases.

3. Modern, visually appealing store layout - The store is designed with a modern and attractive layout that enhances the shopping experience. A visually appealing environment makes customers feel comfortable and engaged, encouraging them to browse longer and return in the future.

4. Prime location at Nugegoda junction with high foot traffic - Being situated at a busy junction in Nugegoda exposes Bootz to a large number of potential customers every day. This strategic location increases visibility, drives walk-in traffic, and creates more opportunities for sales.

Weaknesses

1.Limited Product Visibility - Bootz often faces challenges with the availability of certain shoe sizes, especially in popular designs. This limited visibility means that customers may not always find the products they want, leading to dissatisfaction. As a result, some potential buyers may choose to shop at competitors that consistently have the sizes and styles they need.

2. Higher Product Prices - Bootz's products are priced higher than many local alternatives. In the current economic climate, where customers are more price-sensitive, this can discourage some buyers from making purchases. While the higher prices reflect the quality and style of the products, they can still be a barrier for budget-conscious customers.

3. Dependence on In-Store Visits - Currently, Bootz relies solely on its physical store in Nugegoda for sales. This dependence limits its reach to only those customers who can visit the store. Without an online presence, the brand misses out on potential customers from other areas who may be interested in its stylish and high-quality products.

Opportunities

1.Social Media Presence - Bootz already maintains active social media platforms such as Facebook and Instagram. This is a valuable opportunity to promote products, engage with customers, and drive traffic to the store. Through targeted advertisements, special promotions, and regular customer interactions, Bootz can build brand awareness, attract new customers, and increase loyalty — all at a relatively low marketing cost.

2. E-commerce Expansion - Expanding into an online store provides Bootz with the chance to reach customers beyond the local area. By offering products online, the store can increase sales, improve accessibility for distant customers, and enhance overall visibility. This expansion complements the physical store while helping the brand grow its market presence.

Threats

1.Import Restrictions - Bootz relies on imported footwear, so ongoing limitations on imports pose a significant challenge. Restrictions can reduce the variety and availability of products in the store, making it difficult to meet customer demand and maintain a competitive edge.

2. Economic Climate - The fluctuating national economy affects customers' discretionary spending. Many consumers may become price-sensitive, which can reduce sales of premium footwear and handbags. Additionally, rising VAT rates on imported goods increase costs for Bootz, which may impact pricing and profitability.

3. Intense Competition - Bootz faces strong competition from both local and international footwear brands. For example, being located next to the well-established DSI showroom, which has strong customer loyalty, poses a threat as it may draw potential customers away. The crowded market makes it essential for Bootz to differentiate itself through quality, service, and marketing strategies.



Challengers Faced by Bootz Footwear

Initial Problem

Bootz Footwear is a retailer of stylish and high-quality shoes and handbags located in Nugegoda, Sri Lanka. The business primarily specializes in importing its products to offer premium designs. However, during the recent economic crisis, Bootz faced significant challenges in importing new stock. This led to situations where customers could not find their preferred sizes or styles in-store, resulting in disappointment, lost sales opportunities, and stagnant inventory.

Actions Taken and the Consequences

To address the stock shortages, the owner began sourcing footwear from local shoe businesses to continue operations and meet customer demand. This approach helped ensure that products were available, so customers could still make purchases. However, many customers were initially skeptical about the quality of locally produced shoes compared to the imported footwear they were accustomed to. This lack of trust affected sales and customer satisfaction.

After several months, Bootz has resumed importing footwear. Despite this, the previous disappointing customer experiences have created new challenges for the business, including:

- Difficulty in rebuilding customer trust and engagement.
- Limited product visibility, making it harder for customers to discover available styles, new arrivals, and variations.
- Increased complexity in managing a wider and more diverse inventory, leading to challenges in stock control, availability, and turnover.

Proposed Solutions

To address the identified challenges and enhance business efficiency, we propose a set of innovative solutions aimed at improving operations and customer experience. Our approach focuses on three key components:

- **Web-Based E-Commerce Platform:** Establishing a robust online store to reach a wider audience, streamline the purchasing process, and enhance customer convenience.
- **Inventory Management:** Implementing an automated system to track stock levels, reduce errors, and ensure timely restocking, leading to better operational control.
- **Dynamic Promotions:** Enabling real-time marketing campaigns and personalized offers to boost customer engagement and drive sales.

These solutions collectively aim to modernize business operations, improve scalability, and deliver a seamless shopping experience.

Frontend (Client side)

This is the user-facing part of the platform. This is what customers see and interact with when they visit the online store. The main focus here is to provide a smooth, easy and attractive shopping experience for the customers.

Stacks used:

- HTML5 - Page Structure
- CSS3 - Design and responsiveness.
- JavaScript - Interaction
- Fetch API - Communication between frontend and backend

Interface and its contents

1. Home page

This is the landing page of the store. It gives a clear overview of the store and what the store gives and help the customers navigate easily to products or categories they are interested in. This page includes:

- A navigation menu : Contains links to shop, cart, review and contact pages
- Promotional banners : Highlights discounts, offers, and featured products.
- Search bar : Allows users to quickly find specific products

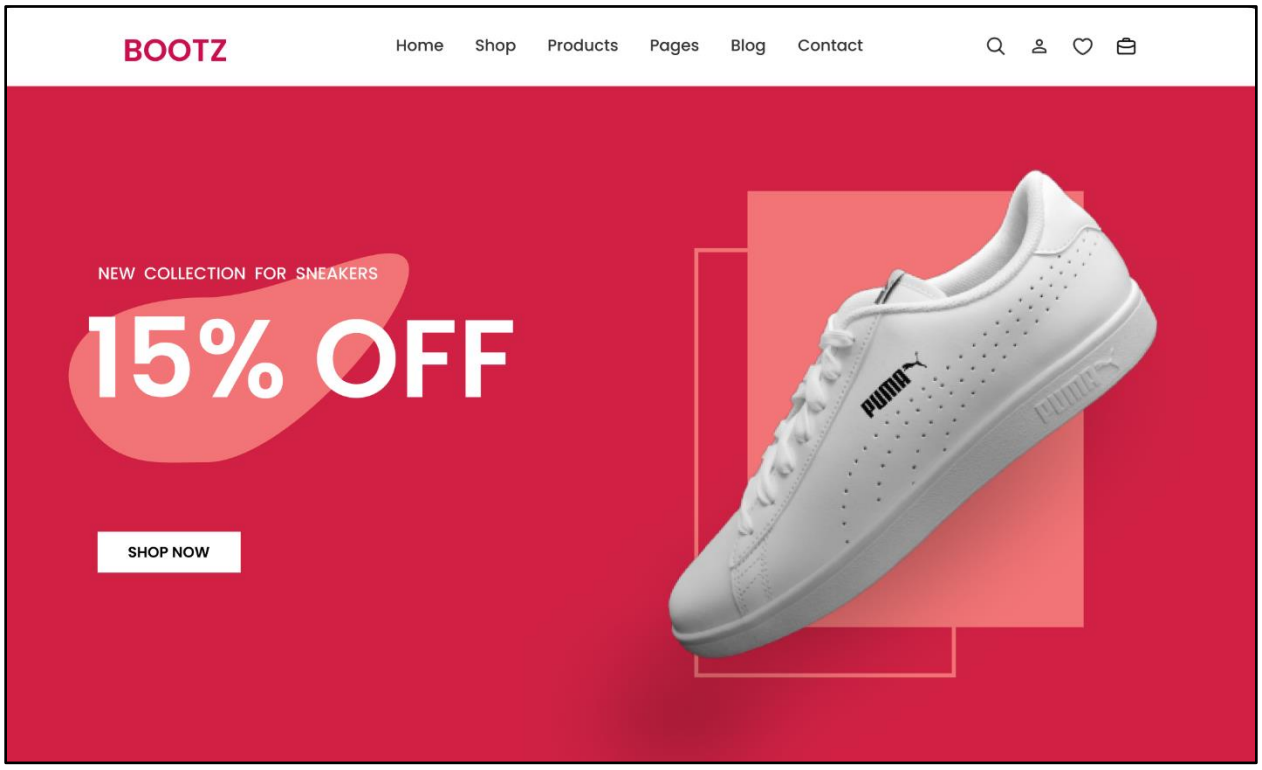


Figure 1: Homepage

2.Product Catalogue Page

This section displays and organizes all available products clearly making it easy for the customers to browse, compare and select the items they're interested in.

- Product image, name, price, and a short description
- "Buy Now" button : For quick purchasing.
- Filters and sorting options (e.g., by size, price, or category)

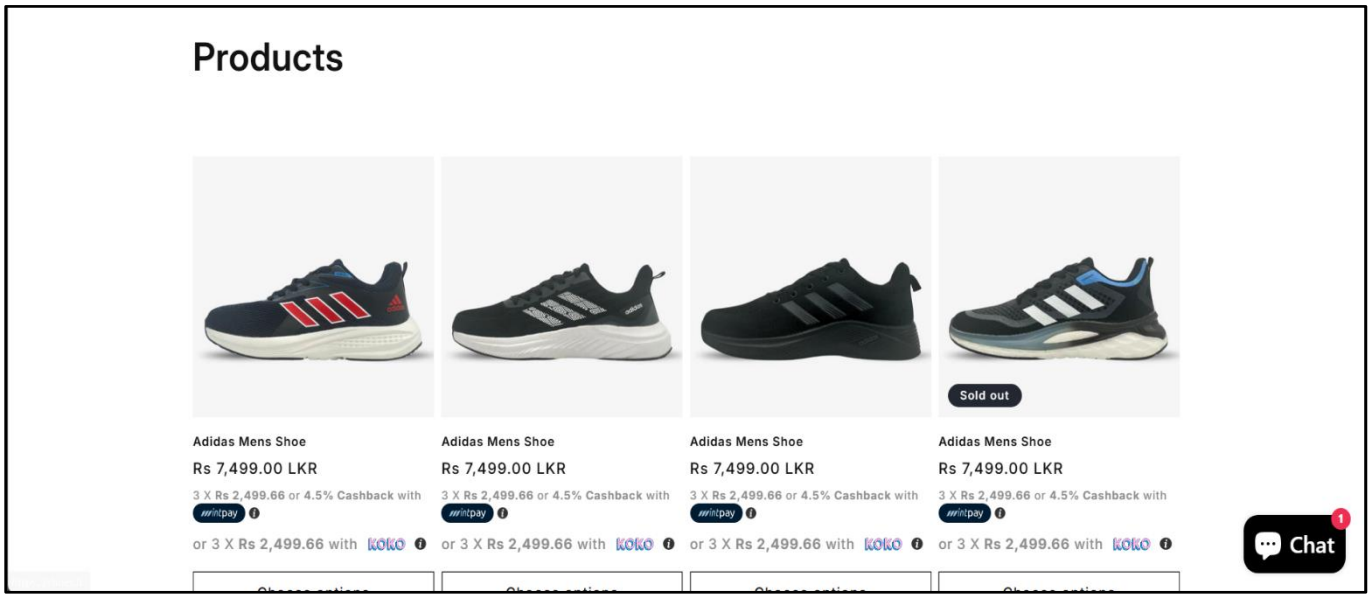


Figure 2 : Product Catalogue page

3. Product page

This page provides complete information about a specific product, helping customers make an informed purchasing decision.

- Product image – Shows the item from different angles.
- Detailed description – Includes size, material and features.
- Price and availability – Shows cost, applicable discount (If any) and stock status.
- Customer reviews and rating – Builds trust among the customers
- “Add To Cart” – For purchasing

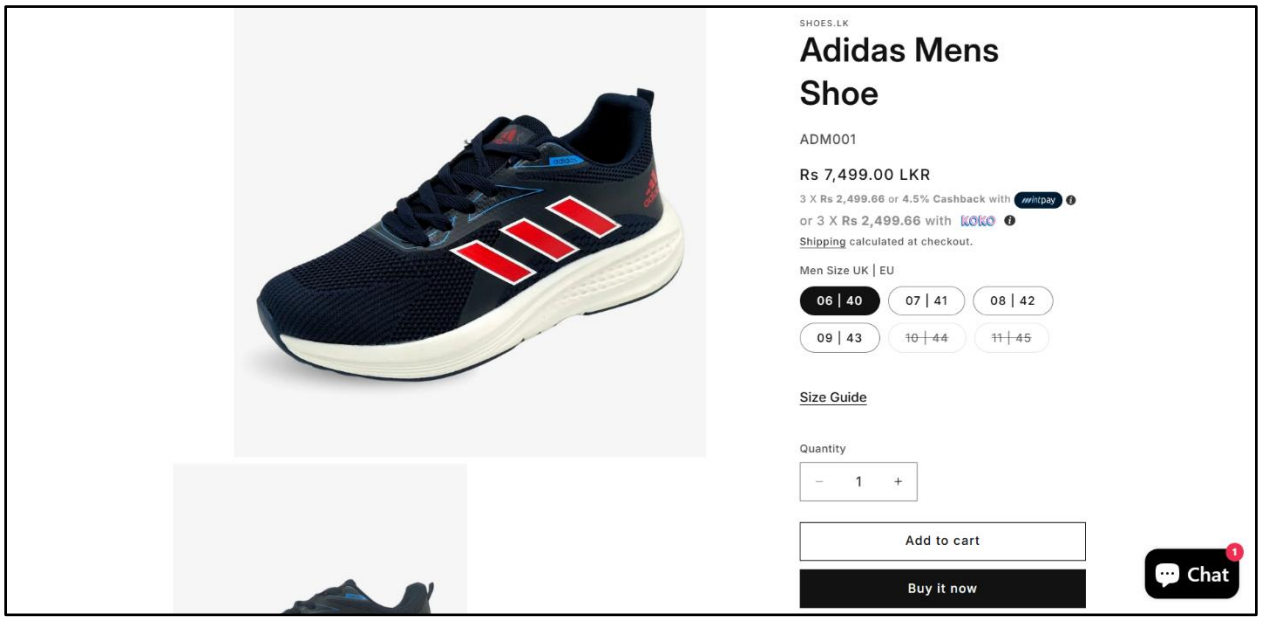


Figure 3 : Product page

4. Shopping cart page

Here customers can review and manage the products they have selected before proceeding to checkout.

- List of the selected products: Shows product names, images, prices, and quantities.
- Edit option : Allows to update the quantity of items or remove products from the cart.
- Price summary : Subtotal, discounts and total cost.
- Proceed to checkout : Allows to continue with the payment process.

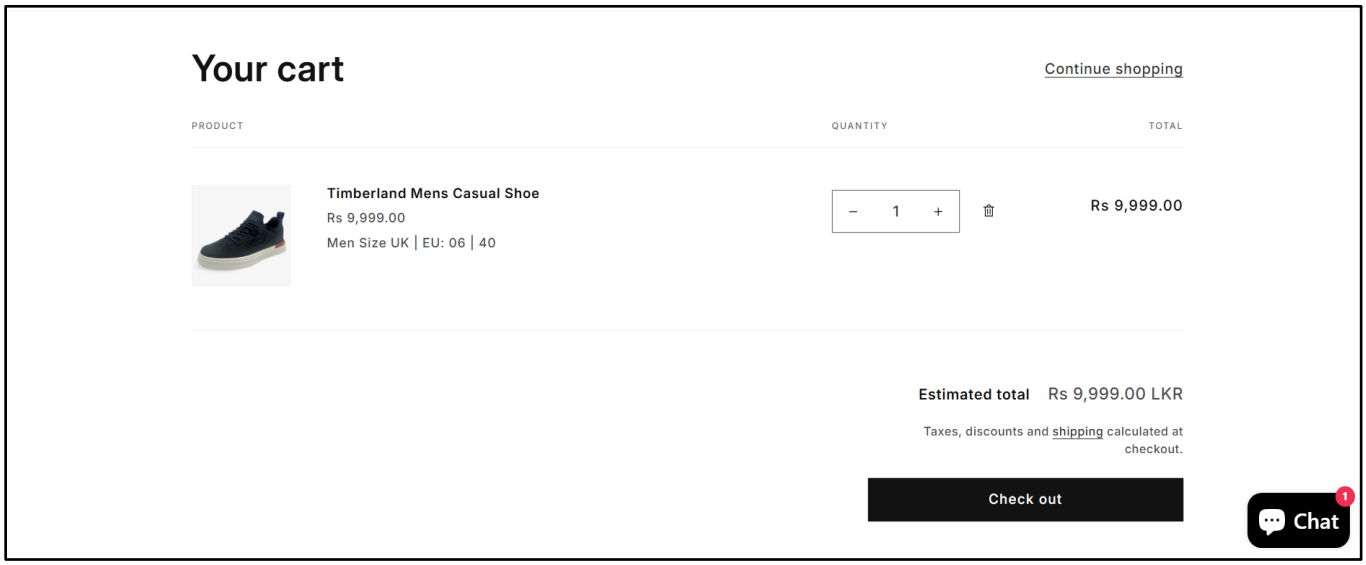


Figure 4 : Shopping Cart page

5. Checkout page

In this page customers enter their details and confirm the order.

- Customer details form : Collects full name, email address, phone number, and delivery address.
- Order summary preview : Shows selected products, quantities, and total cost before payment.
- Secure payment portal : Allows payment through credit/debit cards and other payment methods.

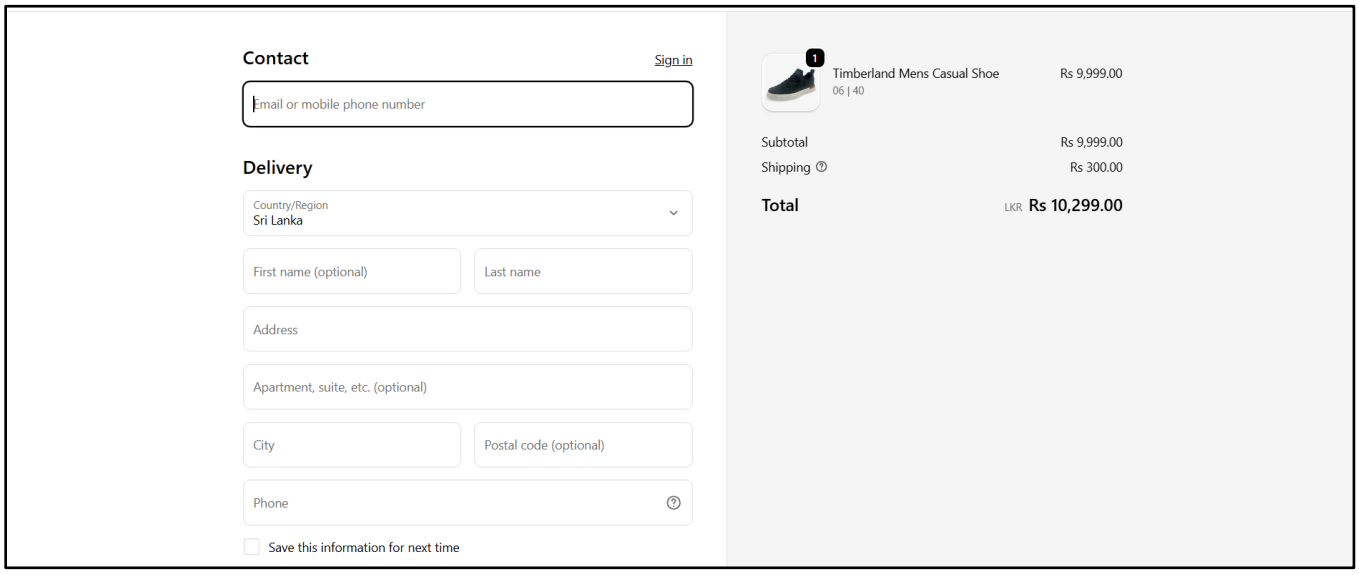


Figure 5 : Checkout page

6. Order confirmation page

- A “Thank You” message : Confirms that the order has been placed.
- A unique order ID : For future reference.
- A notification : Informs the customer that a digital receipt has been sent to their email.

7. Contact us page

This page allows customers to reach out to the business for support, inquiries, or feedback

- A contact form : For submitting messages.
- Business contact details such as phone number, email address, and store location.

8. Review page

The review page enables customers to share their feedback and experiences with the products or services they purchased.

- A form to leave a review about the shop.
- A section displaying reviews and ratings from other customers.
- Filters or sorting options to view reviews by rating or date.

Backend (Server side)

The backend is the hidden part of the system that runs behind the scenes and ensures the website functions smoothly. It is responsible for handling all the server-side operations, including data storage, processing, business logic, and communication between the frontend and the database.

Stacks used:

PHP (Laravel) - Backend

MySQL - Database

PayHere – Payment gateway. Supports Visa, Mastercard, American Express, Discover, Diners Club, Direct bank transfers and mobile wallets.

Brevo – Sends the purchase receipts to customers' mail (transactional mails) and marketing mails.

Webhost.lk - Hosting services

Functions

Admin Dashboard

The Admin Dashboard provides a centralized control panel for managing orders and customer-related activities in the e-commerce store. It is designed to give administrators a complete overview of the store's operations and enable them to handle day-to-day tasks efficiently.

1. Order management

This module allows the administrators to manage all online orders froma single interface. This ensures every order is processed smoothly from purchase to delivery.

- View All Orders: Access a comprehensive list of all orders placed by customers.
- Order Status Tracking: Monitor and update the status of each order (e.g., Pending, Processing, Dispatched, Delivered, or Canceled).
- Order Details: View complete order information such as customer name, items purchased, quantity, price, payment method, and delivery address.
- Update and Manage Orders: Modify order status, initiate refunds, or cancel orders directly from the dashboard.
- Search and Filter Orders: Quickly find specific orders using filters like date, customer name, or status.
- Notifications: Receive alerts for new orders, cancellations, or payment failures to ensure timely action.

2. Customer management

The Customer Management module allows the administrator to efficiently handle all customer-related data and interactions. It helps build strong customer relationships, improve user experience, and support marketing strategies by providing insights into customer activity and purchase behavior.

- View Customer Details & Order History:
  Access detailed customer profiles, including name, contact information, delivery address, and order history. This helps admins track past purchases, payment preferences, and delivery records for better support and personalization.

- Manage Customer Reviews:
  Monitor and moderate customer reviews and ratings on products. Admins can approve, respond to, or remove inappropriate reviews, ensuring the platform maintains credibility and trust.

- Identify Frequent Buyers:
  The system automatically identifies repeat customers by tracking email addresses and phone numbers. This allows the business to recognize loyal customers, send personalized offers, and run targeted marketing campaigns.

- Search & Filter Customers:
  Easily search customers by name, contact details, or order patterns. Admins can segment users based on purchase frequency, location, or spending habits for deeper insights.

- Customer Support & Communication:
  Quickly access customer information to resolve issues, answer queries, or contact them directly for updates and promotions.

3. Reports & Analytics

This provides powerful insights into the performance of the store. This helps administrators make data-driven decisions. It collects and organizes key business data, enabling better planning and strategy development.

- Sales Reports (Daily, Weekly, Monthly):
  Access comprehensive sales summaries over different time periods to

monitor revenue growth and track performance. This helps in understanding sales patterns, seasonal demand, and peak business periods.

- Customer Insights & Repeat Buyers:
  Identify loyal customers who make frequent purchases. These insights can be used for loyalty programs, targeted marketing campaigns, and personalized offers to boost retention.

- Top-Selling Products & Inventory Planning:
  Track the most popular products and categories to understand customer preferences. This data helps in making informed decisions about stock management, pricing strategies, and promotional campaigns.

6. Payment & Finance Overview

This module provides administrators with complete visibility and control over all financial activities within the platform. It ensures smooth payment processing, accurate financial tracking, and simplified reporting for accounting and auditing purposes.

- Transaction Tracking:
  View and monitor all transactions in real time, categorized as successful, pending, or failed. This helps the admin quickly identify any payment issues, verify completed orders, and follow up on incomplete transactions.

- Refund Processing:
  Easily initiate and manage refunds directly from the dashboard. Admins can process partial or full refunds for cancelled or returned orders, improving customer satisfaction and maintaining transparent financial records.

- Export & Reporting for Accounting:
  Export transaction data in formats like CSV or Excel for accounting, tax filing, or auditing. This feature simplifies financial reporting and ensures compliance with business and legal requirements.

7. **Inventory management**

The Inventory Management module helps the admin monitor and control product stock levels efficiently. It tracks available quantities, automatically updates inventory after orders, cancellations, or returns, and sends low-stock alerts to prevent shortages. (This feature is explained in detail later in the report.)

Security and Backup

7) Backup & Recovery (Laravel Backup)

The Backup & Recovery module ensures the safety, integrity, and availability of all platform data by creating secure copies of the database and allowing quick restoration when needed. This feature is crucial for protecting the system against data loss caused by system crashes, accidental deletions, or cyberattacks. Larevel, which is a PHP package is used for backup process.

- Automated Daily Backups:
  The system automatically creates daily backups of critical data, including products, orders, customers, and payment records, without requiring manual intervention.

- Manual Backup & Restore:
  Administrators can initiate manual backups anytime and restore previous versions of the database directly from the dashboard if issues occur.

- Secure Data Storage:
  All backups are stored securely in Onedrive, ensuring data integrity and protection against unauthorized access or corruption.

8. Security

The Security & Authentication module is a critical part of the platform. It is designed to protect sensitive data, prevent unauthorized access, and ensure safe transactions.

- Secure Admin Login with Role-Based Access Control:
  Only authorized users can access the admin dashboard. Different access levels (e.g. Admin, Staff) are assigned based on roles, ensuring that users can only perform tasks relevant to their responsibilities.

- Data Validation:
  All user inputs are thoroughly validated and sanitized before being processed or stored. This helps prevent common security vulnerabilities such as SQL injection, cross-site scripting (XSS), and other malicious attacks.

- SSL/HTTPS Encryption for All Transactions:
  The platform enforces SSL/HTTPS protocols to encrypt all data transmitted between the user's browser and the server. This ensures that sensitive

information like payment details, login credentials, and personal data remain private and protected during online transactions.

- Session Management & Logout Control:
  Secure session handling prevents unauthorized access to admin accounts, while automatic session timeouts and forced logout options add an extra layer of protection.

Cost of stack used

1. PayHere – 2.5% for each transaction

2. Brevo – Free plan – 300 mail/day

Starter plan - $9/month – 5000 mails/day

3. Webhost.lk – Hosting services- Rs.2900

Domain purchase – Rs.5800

Extra Features & Database Design

To enhance the performance, scalability, and customer satisfaction of the e-commerce platform, several extra features and a robust database design were introduced. These additions not only improve user experience but also provide efficient management capabilities for administrators.

Extra Features

Colombo-Only Delivery (Postal Code Verification)

To ensure smooth and reliable delivery, the platform currently supports orders exclusively within the Colombo area.

- The backend database maintains valid postal codes for Colombo.
- During checkout, customers are required to enter their postal code.
- If the entered code matches, the order continues successfully.
- If the code does not match, the system displays an error message preventing order completion.

This feature enables controlled delivery operations and avoids logistical challenges outside the target area.

Session-Based Recommendation System

To increase engagement and improve product discovery, a recommendation engine was implemented using session tracking.

- Each visitor is assigned a temporary session ID when browsing the website.
- The system tracks actions such as viewed products and categories.
- Based on this data, the system suggests related or similar items to the customer in real time.
- When the session ends, the data is cleared, ensuring privacy.

This feature boosts sales opportunities while keeping the browsing experience personalized and seamless.

Database Design

Platform Used: MySQL (phpMyAdmin with XAMPP).

The database design ensures that product storage, stock management, and order tracking operate in real time.

Key Features of the Database:

- Product Storage: Full details stored (name, category, brand, price, description, image).
- Stock Tracking: Handles product variants (size, color, quantity).
- Real-Time Updates: Inventory is reduced automatically after reservations/orders.
- Low-Stock Alerts: Admin is notified when stock is below the threshold.
- Reservation Management: Customers can reserve products online.
- Cancellation Handling: Stock is restored automatically if reservation is cancelled.
- Order Integration: Reservations are smoothly converted into confirmed sales.
- Historical Records: Permanent storage of all reservations, cancellations, and orders.
- Search & Filtering: Efficient search by category, brand, size, and price.

System Process Flow

The following flow illustrates how the system operates from product entry to customer order completion:

1. Admin adds a product → stored in the database.
2. Customer searches using filters (brand, size, price, category).
3. Customer reserves or places an order if stock is available.
4. Inventory is updated automatically in real time.
5. If stock falls below threshold, admin receives a low-stock alert.
6. If reservation is cancelled, the system restores the stock quantity.
7. All transactions are permanently logged for analytics and reporting.

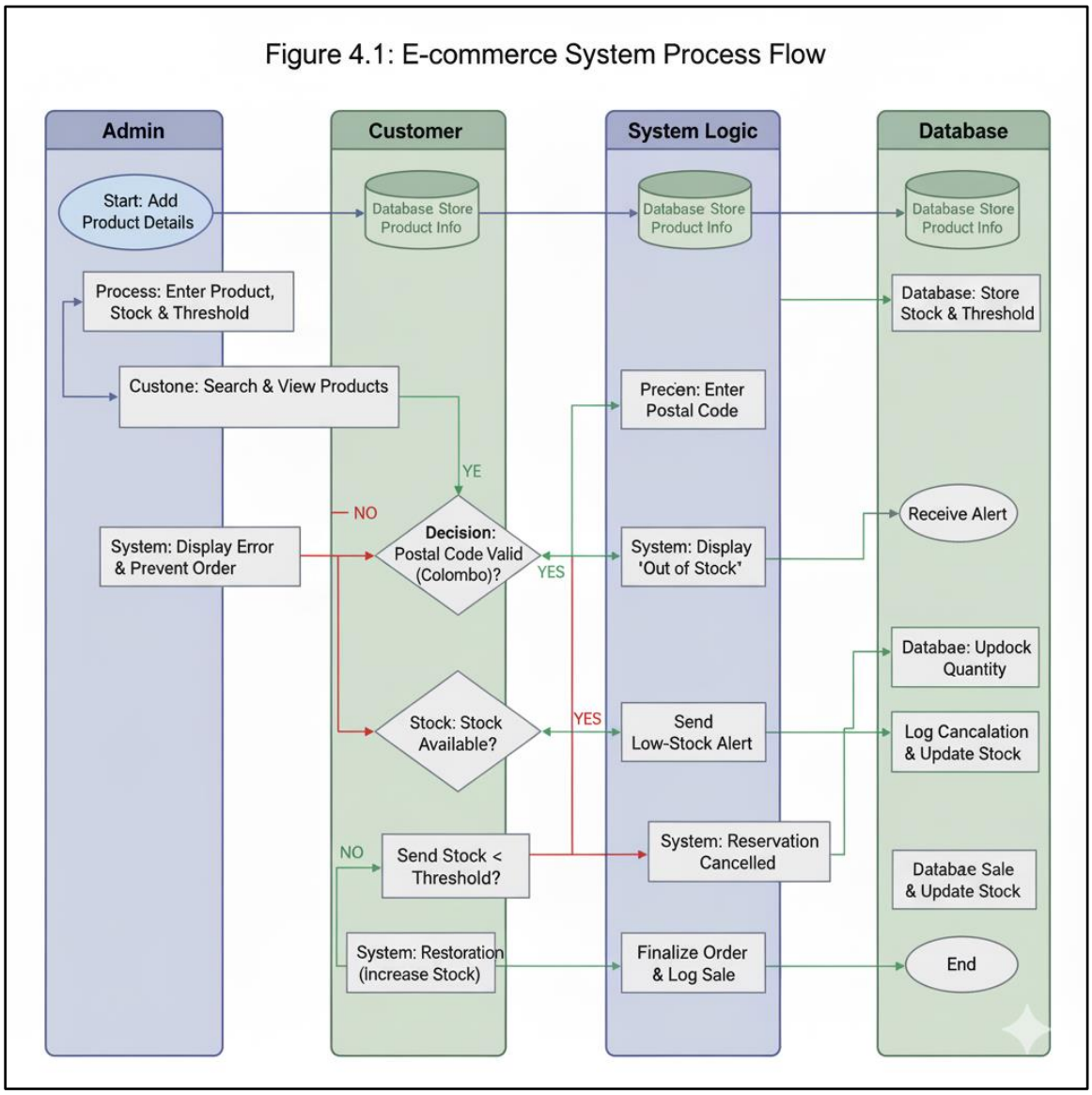


Figure 6 : E-commerce System Process Flow

Dynamic promotions

Dynamic promotions represent a modern marketing tool that adapts to both the business's needs and customer behavior.

- **Stock-based discounts:** When stock levels are high, the system automatically triggers promotional offers to encourage faster turnover. For example, offering a 15% discount on overstocked footwear sizes.
- **Customer-behavior based promotions:** The system tracks browsing activity. If a customer views a particular shoe multiple times without purchasing, the platform can send a limited-time discount to encourage the sale.
- **Trend-driven promotions:** Promotions can also be tied to seasonal demand (e.g., festive discounts) or emerging fashion trends among young adults in Colombo.

These dynamic adjustments ensure that promotions are **relevant, timely, and effective**, rather than being generic or wasteful.

We are considering in several areas for success dynamic promotions. They are target audience, platforms to use, campaign ideas, E-mail marketing and type of content. Now considering one by one;

Target Audience

The promotional strategy focuses on two primary customer groups:

1. **Fashion-conscious young adults** – Individuals who follow the latest styles and trends, seeking footwear that complements their lifestyle.
2. **Trend seekers in Colombo** – Customers who are highly responsive to limited-time offers and new arrivals, valuing exclusivity and uniqueness.

By clearly identifying this audience, Bootz can design tailored promotions that directly appeal to their desires, thereby maximizing engagement.

Campaign Ideas

The success of dynamic promotions relies on creativity and relevance. Bootz can adopt several campaign strategies:

- **Weekly New Arrivals Showcase:** Highlighting the latest footwear collections to create excitement and anticipation.
- **Limited-Time Discounts:** Creating urgency by offering 24–48 hour flash sales on selected items.
- **Customer Stories and Reviews:** Using testimonials and user-generated content to build trust and showcase satisfaction.
- **Seasonal & Festive Campaigns:** Offering discounts during key shopping seasons such as New Year, Sinhala-Tamil New Year, and Christmas.

Such campaigns not only attract attention but also help Bootz stay top-of-mind in the competitive retail market.

Platforms to Use

To ensure maximum reach and impact, promotions should be distributed through multiple channels:

- **Facebook & Instagram:** Building brand awareness, running paid ads, and engaging customers with visually appealing posts.
- **TikTok:** Using trendy, short videos to attract younger audiences with creative product showcases.
- **WhatsApp:** Direct, personalized communication with loyal customers for updates and exclusive offers.

A multi-platform approach ensures Bootz reaches customers wherever they are most active.

Email Marketing

Email marketing is used to keep customers updated and engaged with the brand, while driving repeat purchases through exclusive, personalized offers.

- **Send promotional newsletters** to the customer database.
- **Share exclusive discounts & restock alerts** to maintain excitement and encourage quick purchases.
- **Personalized recommendations** based on past purchases, making customers feel valued and understood.

Because dynamic promotions are based on stock levels, customer behavior, and trends, email campaigns can be customized in real time. For example:

- If stock is low, send a “last chance” email.
- If new arrivals come in, send a “new collection launch” email.
- If a customer left items in their cart, send an **abandoned cart reminder** with a small discount.

Platforms to Use

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- **Facebook & Instagram:** Building brand awareness, running paid ads, and engaging customers with visually appealing posts.
- **TikTok:** Using trendy, short videos to attract younger audiences with creative product showcases.
- **WhatsApp:** Direct, personalized communication with loyal customers for updates and exclusive offers.
- **Email Marketing:** Sending newsletters, exclusive discount codes, restock alerts, and personalized recommendations based on previous purchases.

A multi-platform approach ensures Bootz reaches customers wherever they are most active.

Addressing Key Business Weaknesses through E-Commerce

- **Rebuilding Customer Trust:** Customers can now see detailed product descriptions, high-quality images, and verified reviews, giving them confidence before purchasing.
- **Improving Visibility:** Online catalogues and social media presence allow customers to browse styles, colors, and sizes at any time, overcoming the limitations of a single physical location.
- **Inventory Management:** The integrated system tracks stock in real-time, updates availability automatically, and reduces errors. This ensures popular items remain available while preventing overstocking.
- **Reducing Reliance on Foot Traffic:** With online sales, Bootz is no longer dependent only on its Nugegoda store. Customers from Colombo and beyond can purchase with ease.

Conclusion

Bootz Footwear, a premier footwear and handbag retailer, has successfully identified its strengths in style, quality, and location while also addressing weaknesses such as limited visibility, dependence on in-store sales, and difficulty in maintaining customer trust. The economic crisis and import restrictions created challenges in product availability and customer satisfaction, but the shift toward an integrated **e-commerce solution** provides a sustainable path forward.

The newly proposed platform introduces **dynamic promotions, smart inventory management, secure online transactions, and multi-channel marketing strategies**. By leveraging these tools, Bootz can:

- **Rebuild customer trust** through detailed product descriptions, high-quality images, and verified customer reviews.
- **Increase visibility** with an online catalogue and active social media presence that showcase new arrivals, styles, and seasonal offers.
- **Enhance inventory control** with real-time tracking, automated updates, and low-stock alerts, reducing complexity and improving turnover.
- **Expand market reach** beyond the Nugegoda store, reducing reliance on foot traffic and attracting customers across Colombo and beyond.
- **Boost engagement** through dynamic promotions that adapt to customer behavior, stock levels, and sales trends.
- **Strengthen customer loyalty** with email marketing, personalized recommendations, and targeted campaigns.
- **Build a competitive edge** in Sri Lanka's fashion retail sector by offering a modern, convenient, and secure shopping experience.

In conclusion, the e-commerce transformation is not only a solution to Bootz's current challenges but also a strategic step toward long-term growth. By combining **technology, dynamic promotions, and customer-focused marketing**, Bootz Footwear positions itself as a trusted, innovative, and competitive brand in Colombo's fashion retail market.

Appendix

- Field visit to Bootz Footwear on 13th August 2025

